PIANO BUTLER



The Piano Butler

Handbook

A companion to every room of music

Pitch, time, harmony, expression, form and history, from the whole picture to the smallest detail. For any piece, any method, from the first lesson to Level 8.

PREPARED BY THE PIANO BUTLER · THEPIANOBUTLER.COM

CONTENTS

A map of music

Six parts, from the largest idea to the smallest detail. Read a part from the start for the whole picture, or go straight to the table you need.

PART I Pitch

Where notes sit: from the keyboard and the staff to scales and keys.

The keyboard 8
The staff and the clefs 10
Intervals 14
Scales 18
Keys and key signatures 24
Related keys 28
Modes 30
Transposition 32

PART II Time

How music moves: the pulse, the bar, the length of every note.

Pulse and the bar 36
Notes and rests 38
Time signatures 40
Rhythm 44

PART III Harmony

Notes sounding together, and how they lead somewhere.

Chords 50
Cadences 56
Non-chord notes 60
Chromatic chords 62

PART IV Expression

The signs and words that tell you how to play.

Signs 66
How to play: tempo, dynamics, touch 70
Ornaments 76

PART V Shape and style

How pieces are built, and the music of each age.

Melody 80
Texture 82
Form 84
Kinds of pieces 88
Periods 92
Composers 96

PART VI Playing and listening

The body at the piano, and the ear.

Technique 102
Aural 108
Instruments 112

Glossary · every music word, A to Z 116

Index 124

PART II

Time

Music moves through time. Underneath it runs a steady **pulse**; the pulse is grouped into **bars**; and every note and rest takes up a measured share of it. This part goes from that big picture down to the length of a single note.

1 **Pulse** — the steady beat underneath

›

2 **Bar** — beats grouped: 2, 3 or 4

›

3 **Time signature** — how many beats, and which note is one beat

›

4 **Note values** — how long each note lasts

›

5 **Rhythm** — the pattern of long and short

IN THIS PART

Pulse and the bar 36
Notes and rests 38
Time signatures 40
Rhythm 44

PART II · TIME

Notes and rests

A note's shape shows how long it lasts. Each plain note lasts **half as long** as the one above it; a **dot** adds half the note's value again. Every note has a rest of the same length: a silence, counted just as carefully.

NOTE	REST	NAME	BEATS*	FIRST MET
		**breve**	**8**	Level 4
		**dotted semibreve**	**6**	*beyond Level 8*
		semibreve	**4**	Level 0
		**dotted minim**	**3**	Level 0
		**minim**	**2**	Level 0
		**dotted crotchet**	**1½**	Level ½
		**crotchet**	**1**	Level 0
		**dotted quaver**	**¾**	Level 3
		**quaver**	**½**	Level 0
		**semiquaver**	**¼**	Level 2
		**demisemiquaver**	**⅛**	*beyond Level 8*
		**hemidemisemiquaver**	**1/16**	*beyond Level 8*

* With the crotchet as one beat, as in 2/4, 3/4 and 4/4.

Groups of other sizes



Triplet: three notes in the time of two.
Level 2



Duplet: two notes in the time of three.
Level 3

See also

Time signatures 40
Rhythm 44

Practise it

Workbook Level 0 · Note values
Online · Library › Notes and rests